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LEGISLATURE - Ex-L.A. Councilman Dennis Zine to run for Valley Assembly seat

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Former Los Angeles City Councilman Dennis Zine is running for the California Assembly seat thrown open by the Matt Dababneh sexual-misconduct scandal, saying he'll stand up for west San Fernando Valley taxpayers frustrated by a lack of problem-solving in state government.

Zine, 70, whose last run for office was a losing bid for L.A. city controller in 2013, has been a registered Republican but said he'll campaign for the Assembly as an independent.

Zine made his announcement Monday on the

phone to a Daily News reporter as he drove back to his West Hills home after filing campaign paperwork with county election officials in Norwalk.

He said his decision to enter the contest, in which declared candidates include Democrats Jesse Gabriel and Tricia Robbins Kasson, is "born of frustration" about crime, homelessness and freeway gridlock.

"People throw their hands up and say, 'Nothing's getting fixed. All they want to do is raise taxes and fees.' People say, 'Is my quality of life improving?' " Zine said.

The April 3 special election primary is being held to fill the final year of Dababneh's term in the 45th Assembly District and to fill out the terms of L.A.-area Assemblymen Raul Bocanegra, who resigned because of sexual harassment accusations, and Sebastian Ridley-Thomas, who quit for health reasons.

If no candidate gets an outright majority in April, a runoff will be held June 5. The latter also is the day of primaries for the regular state elections. Zine entered both the special and regular elections.

The boisterous, Harley-Davidson-riding former L.A. policeman becomes the biggest personality and best-known candidate in the election in a district that includes West Hills, Woodland Hills, Winnetka, Encino, Reseda, Tarzana, Northridge, Calabasas and Hidden Hills, overlapping much of Zine's old 3rd City Council District.

But Zine's colorful past could cause trouble for him in an election season when gender relations in the workplace, including the state Capitol, are likely to be an issue.

In 1999, when he was a director of the L.A. police union, Zine was accused by a female LAPD officer of making inappropriate advances during a business trip. Zine was absolved by an LAPD disciplinary board, but panel member Cmdr. Dan Koenig wrote in the decision: "Our verdict is hardly a vindication of Sgt. Zine's actions, for many of his decisions reflect unbelievably poor judgment."

Toward the end of his City Council career, Zine faced questions about whether he recused himself often enough from council votes on issues involving companies for which his girlfriend of 10 years was a lobbyist.

On Monday, Zine said those issues "have been aired. They've been discussed. It's in the past."

Saying sexual harassment "shouldn't be tolerated," Zine also expressed concern that some men accused of sexual misconduct are being driven out of jobs by public opinion instead of due process. He declined to say if he's happy Dababneh and Bocanegra resigned, saying, "They chose to do what they did."

The 45th Assembly District race lost one candidate last week to accusations of sexual discrimination. Samantha Stevens, a Democrat, suspended her campaign as political insiders began to focus on a 2013 lawsuit, which was settled in 2015, that claimed Stevens, then an executive with the Service Employees International Union, had discriminated against employees based on gender, age and family status. Stevens complained that she was pushed out of the race by L.A. City Councilman Bob Blumenfield and his political adviser, Larry Levine, who support Robbins Kasson, an aide to Blumenfield and a client of Levine.

A longtime Republican who served from 2001 to 2013 on the officially nonpartisan L.A. City Council, Zine would be the only member of the state Legislature who's neither a Republican nor a Democrat if he wins as an independent.

"I believe that an independent can represent everyone," Zine said. "You're not tied to one party. You can really focus on what is right for the people."

Rick Taylor, Zine's campaign consultant, said Zine fit with the Republican Party "when it was a party of reason. Today it's more extreme." Taylor described Zine's record in City Hall as "pretty progressive" on social issues but conservative on fiscal matters.

Asked about President Trump, Zine said: "I think they need to take his cellphone and tweeter away. ... As far as what he's doing, it's not all negative, but there is a lot of negative that's been coming out that's causing upheaval for people."

Democrats outnumber Republicans by more than 2 to 1 among 45th Assembly District voters. The deadline to declare candidacies for the April election is Feb. 8. Four candidates other than Zine have filed "statements of intention" to run: Democrats Gabriel, Robbins Kasson and Raymond Bishop, and Republican Justin Clark. Two other Democrats, Ankur Patel and Serena Sharp, have filed statements for the June primary.

Gabriel reacted to Zine's entry into the race by saying: "We need a principled Democrat to represent us in Sacramento. Not someone who is trying to hide the fact that they're a Republican. I'm running to fight for education, health care, the environment, transportation and better jobs for our community."

Levine, campaign consultant to Robbins Kasson, said: "I think Dennis Zine represents the past. Given the challenges we face now, we need somebody more forward-looking. Certainly, his controversial history with regards to many of the issues of today raise questions as to what he's thinking when he wants to run for office."

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